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At a minimum, the art and architecture of the monastery need only be conducive to such ends, although the tendencies of Thai art are anything but minimalistic.

.. are sites of accretion. An aesthetic of abundance (udom sombun) is highly valued.¹ In their more concrete manifestations, abundance and accretion can take the form of manifold ornaments on and elaborations of the otherwise basic and boxy architectural form of the image halls, the plethora of images and offerings that crowd a typical altar, or the complex and detailed composition of most mural paintings.

But these principles of accretion and abundance are not limited to the intricacy and horror vacui so characteristic of Thai art: they can also account for the presence of objects that, to eyes conditioned by the conventional categories of art history, might appear foreign, secular, or otherwise out of place (Fig. 1).

One very distinctive example is the Chinese export art, primarily reverse glass paintings, that can be still be found in a number of monasteries in Bangkok that were built or restored in the second quarter of the nineteenth century (Fig. 2).

As objects of foreign origin whose presence is best explained by their appeal to the predilections of the temples' patrons, these paintings can certainly be considered accretions, but also, in their own status as commodities of a lucrative international trade and often in their imagery as well, they reflect the aesthetic of abundance that lends an air of auspiciousness to a monastery (Fig. 3).

The preference for Chinese-style art and architecture that was incorporated into the design and decoration of a number of Bangkok monasteries during the first half of the nineteenth century forms a fascinating interlude in the history of Thai art. The monasteries of this era are famous for their architectural innovations simplified roof lines, for example as well as new designs found in mural paintings, such as *toh bucha baep jin* (Chinese altar tables) and scenes from the fourteenth-century novel *Romance of the Three Kingdoms*. Many of these are hybrid visual forms, Chinese imagery adapted by Chinese-Thai artists for Thai religious spaces.

Some reverse glass paintings closely resemble the new mural designs and, in some cases, may have served as models or inspiration.

To date, the Chinese glass paintings that ended up in the monasteries patronized by the Thai aristocracy have yet to capture the attention and imagination of the scholarly community in the same manner as have the murals in the same temples, despite tantalizing visual correspondences between the two.

Perhaps this is because the glass paintings were imports rather than local adaptations of Chinese art, or maybe, as accretions, they are too easily dismissed as distinct from or even ancillary to the material fabric of the buildings that house them and the murals that surround them.

However, a closer look at the glass paintings suggests that they were integral components of the Sino-Thai art of Siam's Third Reign (1824–51), inspiring new aesthetic directions in mural painting and reflecting the intimate relationships between Siam and China before trade and diplomacy with Europe took center stage.

Illustrating his remarks with a photograph of one of the *Samkok* battle scenes from Wat Nangnong, he alluded to the broad global circulation of glass paintings in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries and highlighted their role as a vehicle for the transfer of visual styles between cultures, as well as the relativization of low versus high art styles that frequently resulted from such border crossings.² This article will expand on Clark's ideas by connecting them with the glass paintings that can be found in Bangkok, showing how they originated as marketable commodities and subsequently were recontextualized into elite social spaces.

(Rama III, r. 1824–51) as an influential patron of Chinese-style art in Bangkok is also examined. This article demonstrates ways that glass paintings might have served as vehicles for the transfer of new images and ideas into Thai temple murals.

Painting in Reverse on Glass

The technique demands that artists lay down the pigments in the reverse of the customary order in which paintings are constructed: the fine details and foreground imagery must be applied first, and only at the end of the process can the broad strokes of the background be filled in (an exception can be made if the pigments are unusually thin and transparent).

The origins of reverse glass painting are distant and obscure; the earliest surviving examples date from the Roman Empire, and there are medieval and Renaissance examples from many parts of Europe.³ These early examples tend to be decorative objects, miniatures, or augmentations to other crafts, but from the sixteenth to the nineteenth centuries glass painting flourished in the form of framed pictures.

The current obscurity of reverse glass paintings, together with their general omission from the standard histories of art, owes much to their widespread association with common rather than elite tastes.

The rarity of the objects made them highly prized: Frieder Ryser notes that in 1763, an imported Chinese painting (64 cm x 38 cm) depicting a lady and a sherman on a riverbank was assessed at 600 livres in Port Louis, whereas the value of François Boucher's (1703-1770) oil paintings that year did not exceed 350 livres, even though Boucher was already at the height of his career as Rococo's most celebrated artist.⁵ Eighteenth-century writers were uncertain about the precise circumstances through which the medium had taken root in China, speculating that the techniques might have been introduced there by Jesuit missionaries.⁶ Modern accounts are no less tentative.

The pictures were painted with conventions that owed more to European than Chinese art, such as dramatic (if not linearly precise) perspective, shading to establish three-dimensional forms, and the heavy, brooding foliage characteristic of eighteenth-century English landscape painting.

Chinese glass paintings are just one format of the diverse category export art, which includes not only painted pictures in various media (such as gouache or oils on glass, paper, canvas, and other grounds) but also a variety of other arts and crafts, such as ceramics and furniture, that China produced in the eighteenth and nineteenth centuries for export to foreign countries.

The Peabody Essex Museum in Salem, Massachusetts—a city that formerly was among the most active American ports in the China trade—houses an extensive collection of Chinese export art, including a number of reverse glass paintings.

Even though the first paintings on glass imported from China to Europe in the mid-eighteenth century commanded impressive prices, by the mid-nineteenth century they were little more than common curiosities: a British estate catalogue from 1848 asks only three pounds, seven shillings for a lot of forty such paintings, a valuation that did not greatly exceed that of their frames.⁸ Today, a few glass paintings turn up from time to time whenever the major auction houses put together a sale of Chinese export art, and then vanish again into private collections, usually selling for a modest price.

Chinese glass paintings, most of which were made anonymously, have little market value compared with works from established artists, and their aesthetic qualities are not usually of the kind preferred by connoisseurs of either Eastern or Western art. They are implicitly hybrid and commoditized objects, produced by the craftsmen of one region to meet the consumer preferences of another.

To date, Chinese export art has been studied primarily as an artifact of trade between China and Western nations.

The research, largely historical and descriptive, has focused on the late stages of chinoiserie, early American entrepreneurship, and the material goods involved in those transactions.⁹ The discovery of numerous glass paintings in the temples of Bangkok demonstrates that there was also an Eastern market for Chinese export art, a revelation that adds a new dimension to this field.

Cultural Transfer and Relativization

In *Modern Asian Art* John Clark devotes an entire chapter to the concept of the transfer of images and ideas between cultures through the medium of portable art, and Chinese glass paintings are implicated in two distinct spheres of cultural transfer.¹¹ First, the works were produced in southern China, particularly Guangzhou, as part of a larger category of China-trade paintings that incorporated a variety of media, techniques, styles, and sometimes imagery copied from European painting.

Subsequently, these already implicitly hybrid objects were circulated back to countries outside China, where association with their place of origin redefined them as genuine specimens of Chinese art, taking on, in the country of destination, the status associated with Chinese culture.

Whereas Chinese glass paintings never rose to the status of fine art in European collections, remaining mere souvenirs or collectibles, those that were imported to Bangkok fared much better: they were given a place of great prominence in the decor of eminent palaces and monasteries (Fig. 4).

Moreover, the fact that glass paintings served as vehicles for the transfer of new forms of Chinese imagery that began to appear in Thai temple murals demonstrates that, from the viewpoint of the Thai, the authenticity and authority of these paintings to serve as exemplars

of Chinese art was not in question.

Recognizing glass paintings as an important vector for image transfer between China and Siam in the first half of the nineteenth century provides one key to understanding why the Chinese-style mural paintings that began to appear in Bangkok's monasteries have very little in common with the style of paintings deemed prestigious in China.

In China, glass paintings were an unredeemably low-status form of art. One would be challenged to come up with a type of painting more at odds with every value cherished by the elite art discourse of the era.

Among the taste-making Chinese literati, artworks were required to conform to established conventions of style, material, and mythology: elegantly bland and sparsely monochromatic; reverent of past masters yet revealing the spirit of the artist through spontaneous brushwork; painted in albums or scrolls carefully labeled and stored; and, ideally, exchanged through transactions modeled on gift-giving rather than blatant cash trades.

So far did such works lay outside the elite art discourse in China that they were beneath criticism altogether, dismissed from discussions of the art as completely as today's art world ignores the hand-painted copies of famous paintings that one can order through Chinese websites.

In fact, it might not be going too far to identify the glass paintings as an earlier iteration of the same phenomenon, given that a significant portion of the activity of glass-painting workshops was directed toward the reproduction of pre-existing imagery, much of it imported from Western sources.¹² In making aesthetic judgments, the aristocracy of early-nineteenth-century Siam had little access to the canons of literati taste that dominated elite aesthetic productions in China.

In consequence, the perception of Chinese art that prevailed in Siam was heavily informed by folk culture and imported goods and little touched by the rarefied scholarly discourse of the Chinese literati.

Given that neither the expatriate Chinese merchants nor the local Thai aristocracy in Siam had been indoctrinated into the literati mode of Chinese art criticism, it is easy to understand how the glass paintings achieved a sudden and dramatic relativization of status upon entering nineteenth-century Siam much like they had in eighteenth-century France.

These cheap, mass-produced articles of the export trade had only to cross the right borders to be elevated into respectable examples of Chinese art that were deemed suitable for installation in elite spaces, such as the royal palaces of Bangkok as well as the capital's most lavish and important monasteries.

The eminence of glass paintings in early-nineteenth-century Siam was very unusual given the broader history of this medium, one that in most times and places has operated as a separate, distinctly inferior sphere of image-making.

Even in Siam glass paintings were collected and displayed in the residences and temples of the wealthy for only a limited period.

Chinese art and imagery became less prominent in temple and palace decoration, although it was never discontinued altogether.

Despite the many Chinese glass paintings imported to Siam in the early nineteenth century, this art form did not establish strong roots in the new land.

Two prominent exceptions are the use of distinctively Thai designs in a set of glass paintings in Wat Phra Kaew, as well as a set of framed pictures in Wat Suthat that do not appear to be painted on glass but occupy a similar spatial and decorative niche as the glass paintings in the other temples (Fig. 5).¹³ Apart from these sets in very significant state temples, and a few other examples that will be discussed below, there is little evidence of a successful or enduring transplantation of the glass painting tradition to central Siam.

Hanging framed paintings over the windows and on the interior columns of temples ceased to be a common practice after 1851, when the Third Reign of the Chakri dynasty concluded with the death of King Nangklao, suggesting the possibility that this practice was inspired and perpetuated largely by his personal taste.

The passing fad for glass paintings among Bangkok's aristocracy was deeply imbricated with the traditional tributary trade with China and the aesthetic preferences of the last monarch under whom that trade had prospered. As relations with China diminished and the new trends in art and architecture drew inspiration from the West, the decoration of temples and palaces with glass paintings and Chinese-style murals quickly became old-fashioned and, finally, obsolete.¹⁴ Although diverse in location and appearance, one thing that these monasteries had in common was a significant degree of patronage by King Nangklao, Bangkok's third ruler, and members of his court.

The aesthetic tastes of an absolute monarch can all too easily drive fashion as courtiers strive to emulate the royal example, seeking favor and prestige.¹⁶ King Nangklao's sinophilia was no secret, and in consequence the Third Reign saw the manifestation of Chinese objects and images throughout Bangkok's public and aristocratic spheres.

Not only was the king a major instigator of this trend, but the installation of imported Chinese glass paintings into Thai Buddhist monasteries occurred at the intersection of three of

the king's chief interests: China, trade, and temples.

For years before he was crowned king in 1824, Prince Chetsadabodin (as he was then titled) had a guiding hand on the reins and, more important, the purse strings of the Thai government.

During its reconstruction in the 1820s, Wat Chom Thong was renamed Wat Ratcha Orot, the Temple of the King's Son. The new, royally appointed name was matched by a suitably elegant appearance: every building was given Chinese architectural flourishes and painted inside with murals deemed to be Chinese in style.

If these walls were adorned with mural paintings, the images could now be fully appreciated from any point within the building, which might have been one of the aims of this architectural revision.

For instance, the principal image in the assembly hall (wihan) of Wat Ratcha Orot is a large reclining Buddha, a prototype for the enormous one constructed at Wat Pho in the late 1830s, its head cushioned on a stack of jeweled pillows and the soles of its feet similarly adorned with 108 auspicious signs derived from the Pali canon of Buddhist texts.¹⁸ Auspicious signs of a very different form and origin dominate the ordination hall of Wat Ratcha Orot, where innovative murals adapted a form of Chinese folk art in which arrangements of fruit, flowers, and assorted other objects encoded sly puns and rebuses that expressed good wishes.

Compositions of this type have no distinct precedent in earlier Thai art but were well represented among the glass paintings imported to Siam.

Whereas each glass painting frames only a single such arrangement, the murals at Wat Ratcha Orot combine hundreds of them, all uniquely differentiated from one another, into a rough grid that spans the breadth and height of the upper interior walls of the ordination hall.

Phanuphong Laahasom and Chaiyot Itworaphan suggest that the relationship between the mirrors and the mural paintings derives from the paintings being understood as fragmentary reflections in a row of angled mirrors.¹⁹ This is a clever and original interpretation, but to defend it obliges one to willfully disregard one of the most prominent visual features of the murals themselves: that the same set of objects is never represented more than once, much less in multiples, something the artists clearly went to great lengths to avoid.

Even in the absence of actual furniture, glass paintings provided a vector for the transfer of this type of imagery: the sets of glass paintings at Wat Kanlayanamit and Wat Arun that I will explore later in this article are composed as though they were individual niches in just such a cabinet, and the arrangements of auspicious and elegant objects in such paintings share a direct thematic resemblance to those in the murals at Wat Ratcha Orot.

John Crawford, who visited the temple on April 22, 1822, observed: Crawford does not state explicitly that the paintings are on glass, but circumstantial evidence suggests that they were: all the other surviving gilt-framed Chinese pictures that were installed in Thai temples during this period are reverse paintings on glass.

Glass, too, by virtue of its transparency, was the ideal medium with which to make copies of published prints simply place the print behind the pane of glass and trace and this practice was not only common in China but also integral to the art of glass painting as it was practiced in Europe.²³ Among the thirteen glass paintings currently in the ordination hall of Wat Phakhinrat are two that appear to be copies of domestic scenes from a European or American source (Fig. 8).

According to Burney, when he entered the Hall of Audience he observed that to each pillar was affixed a large Chinese painting on glass of a European oficer or Lady.²⁴ That Chinese glass paintings ornamented the audience hall in the royal palace during King Nangklao's reign further strengthens the suggestion that it was the king's preference for these paintings that led to their installation in a number of the monasteries that he patronized. It is notable that both Crawford and Burney specified that the paintings they saw portrayed Western imagery, even though they recognized that they were Chinese copies.

It is well established that a substantial part of the output of glass-painting workshops in China consisted of such replicas.

Carl Crossman noted that most of the European prints copied by the Chinese artisans had been published after the 1780s, giving us a rough sense of when this practice of copying began to thrive in China, having found an eager market in the foreign traders at Canton.²⁵ Josef Vydra reported that in Eastern Europe, reverse glass paintings had long been sold as souvenirs from pilgrimage sites.²⁶ A parallel practice can be found in the popularity of glass paintings among the European and American traders in China, who appear to have been the primary market for these commodities.

The thirty images that form the base of the fifteen trios comprise the following: eight paintings of small boats in Danish colors in a short canal in a foreign enclave; six paintings of the Thirteen Factories at Canton; six portraits of various ships, mostly British, of which two are early-model hybrid steamers that have not yet dispensed with full rigging; three views of the Macau waterfront looking across the Praya Grande; three views of Macau from its narrow isthmus; two paintings of the Dutch Folly, a fort in the river near Canton; one of a seaside Chinese temple, possibly at Macau; and one anomalous painting of cavorting mythical animals.

The prevalence of so many nearly identical compositions indicates the likelihood of workshop

production in which artists based each scene on stock templates, a practice for which glass painting was ideally suited. The Thirteen Factories at Canton and the view across Macau's Praya Grande were both especially popular scenes that were widely reproduced in a variety of media during the early decades of the nineteenth century.

This operation is implicit behind the theory of abundance articulated by McDaniels as one of the key aesthetic traits of Thai Buddhism.

The second trait, accretion (referring to the idiosyncratic objects that tend to accumulate in temples as a consequence of such donations), is closely related. Accretion also serves to highlight the relations of individual patrons to the monastery; again, in contrast to Western practice, little value is attached to donating anonymously, so Thai temples are replete with signs and placards specifying who gave what or how much, and, in the case of material objects, the taste of the donor is sometimes reflected in the gift. Considered in relation to the principles of abundance and accretion, the Pearl River Delta paintings are a perfect fit for Wat Pho: it was King Nangklao's profitable trade relations with China that supplied him with the wealth to renovate so many monasteries, Wat Pho included, during his twenty-seven-year reign.

At the apex of each trio of paintings installed on the columns of Wat Pho's ordination hall are fifteen works that, though similar in size, style, and palette to the Pearl River Delta scenes that hang just below them, present us with a different genre that might appear even more incongruous in the setting of a Buddhist temple (see Fig. 9).

Three Kingdoms imagery in a variety of media was a popular theme of palace and temple decoration in the early nineteenth century.³¹ The Chinese epic novel had been translated into Thai just two generations earlier, in the court of Rama I (r. 1782-1809), Bangkok's founder and King Nangklao's grandfather.

The creativity of the artists in glass-painting workshops was not completely stifled: as long as they followed the templates that specified the basic compositions, they could add their own flourishes in the extraneous details.

Although a couple of the smaller paintings are indistinguishable in style from the Three Kingdoms paintings at Wat Thepthidaram and Wat Pho, the larger ones, though they share the same representational conventions—camel-nosed horses, red-knobbed tents, and the uttering pennants and showy armor of the warriors—display greater complexity of composition and skill in rendering (Fig. 13).³⁴ We might speculate that King Nangklao reserved these superior versions of Three Kingdoms paintings for Wat Nangnong, another temple that he extensively patronized, in keeping with his plan for the temple's overall decoration.

The Buddha image on the altar, adorned with kingly regalia, reinforces the story's theme, as do the royal ceremonial implements painted in gilt lacquer on the window frames.³⁵ Wat Nangnong nevertheless reveals the Thai genius for assimilating elements of foreign culture and instilling them with local meaning: on the strips of wall space between the windows are murals of additional scenes from Three Kingdoms in colored gilt lacquer (an artistic technique called *kammalor* in Thai).

This demonstrates that Three Kingdoms was not just an arbitrary story for which glass paintings happened to be available; it meant something to the king, and he installed the paintings as a coherent element of the ordination hall's decoration.

As elements of temple decor that better reflect the idiosyncratic tastes of a particular patron than conventional Buddhist imagery, the Three Kingdoms paintings in Third Reign temples operate as distinct examples of accretion.

Glass Paintings and Image Transfer

This is a difficult question to address because of the enormous popularity of this story during the nineteenth century, enjoyed by the Thais in a variety of media, including literature, theatre, and the visual arts.

The appeal of the story was driven in part by the large influx of Chinese immigrants and in part by the favor of the royal court.

Wat Nangnong, for instance, contains scenes from the story in two different media and styles: the glass paintings hanging over the windows and the gilt-lacquer murals between them.

Glass paintings, then, seem to have been just one conduit for image transfer among a broad and varied influx to Siam of Three Kingdoms imagery from China that must have included performances, printed books, and the mental schema carried by living artists.

As if to underscore this connection, in addition to the four monasteries with Chinese glass paintings that prominently feature Three Kingdoms imagery, similar paintings can also be found in at least two palace buildings.³⁶ For instance, hanging casually amid other domestic decorations in the Vimanmek mansion, a former royal residence, is a glass painting depicting a battle scene from Three Kingdoms that is strikingly reminiscent of those at Wat Nangnong.

There the glass paintings hang over the windows, just as in Wat Nangnong and other temples, but the raised altar at the far end of the room bears not a Buddha image but three golden urns representing the first three kings of the Chakri dynasty.

Boundaries between the royal and the religious are not clearly differentiated in Thai tradition,

where both domains require the use of a special reverent vocabulary that sometimes overlaps, where palace and temple buildings historically enjoyed similar architecture and ornamentation, and where historical kings have become objects of cultic worship in their own right.³⁷ At both Wat Nangnong and the Ho Phra That Monthian, the glass paintings reside on the slippery boundary between royal and religious space.

The ordination hall of Wat Phakhininat, another of King Nangklao's restoration projects, displays thirteen Chinese glass paintings hanging singly over the windows and doors.³⁸ Several of the scenes portray events from the Three Kingdoms tale, easily recognized from the distinctive appearance of the three main heroes: Liu Bei, pale and elegant; Zhang Fei, swarthy and hairy; and Guan Yu, with ruddy complexion and long silky beard (Fig. 14).

These are not generic battle scenes but rather complex narrative moments handled with artistic skill, in all particulars resembling the larger central paintings of the trios at Wat Nangnong.

The two paintings from this temple that replicate a European source image have already been discussed above (see Fig. 8).

Wat Phakhininat is notable for bearing the imprint of King Nangklao's tastes not only in the display of Chinese glass paintings, but also in the unusual mural program.

Whereas the configurations of auspicious objects at Wat Ratcha Orot are still closely derivative of Chinese rebuses, those at Wat Phakhininat teem with an assortment of motifs that, though potentially infused with significance as visual puns, seem to have been chosen more for aesthetic effect than meaning.³⁹ The most important change, however, is the way that the artists have de-emphasized the significance of these objects by visually subordinating them to the fanciful tables and stands that dominate each composition.

Arrangements of auspicious and elegant objects were common enough in Chinese crafts, folk art, and domestic decoration, but how did these images reach Siam?

King Nangklao did not disguise his preference to employ Chinese laborers in the construction of his temples, and the sure hands that inscribed characters in the mural paintings suggest natively acquired literacy.⁴¹ While we cannot discount the possibility of living expertise, difficult to trace in the typically anonymous, unsigned temple murals, there is also a material link.

Surviving sets of glass paintings at two Bangkok monasteries, Wat Kanlayanamit and Wat Arun, reveal a concrete proximate source for the compositional types that inspired the Chinese altar tables design in Thai mural painting.

Glass Paintings of Elegant and Auspicious Objects

On the west bank of the Chao Phraya River, the main artery running through Bangkok and once the epicenter of Sino-Siamese trade, stands a monastery with strong historical ties both to King Nangklao and to the Chinese immigrant community.

Upon completion, he dedicated the whole site to the new king, who expressed his approval by building a magnificent new assembly hall (wihan) in between the two original image halls, bestowing the name Wat Kanlayanamit (Temple of the Beautiful Friend) upon the monastery, and granting Chao Phraya Nikonbodin the right to use Kanlayanamit as his surname, inheritable by his descendants.⁴² In the ordination hall of Wat Kanlayanamit are seventeen reverse glass paintings hung in six trios over the windows and doors the odd number because, as elsewhere, loss has rendered one of the trios incomplete.

Despite the depredations of age, the glass paintings at Wat Kanlayanamit could serve as one of the most valuable clues we have to explain the origin of the Chinese altar table design that first appeared in the mural paintings at Wat Ratcha Orot and were subsequently implemented at Wat Phakhininat.

Vases of flowers and dishes of fruit with traditional auspicious meanings, particularized by connection with other meaningful objects such as coral branches and lingzhi fungus, form the basis of the Wat Kanlayanamit compositions, a genre that in Chinese can be described as zabao, assorted treasures. The larger, central painting of each trio is even garnished with the distinctive squared scrollwork of bright red meander tables.

We cannot know whether the glass paintings at Wat Kanlayanamit were the specific objects that inspired murals of this design on the walls of other temples, but knowing that glass paintings of this compositional type were mass produced for export in China, and imported to Bangkok for the decoration of temples, does establish one explicit channel through which the zabao designs reached Siam and commanded the attention of temple patrons.

Deep within the mazy alleys in the southeastern part of Bangkok's Chinatown hides an architectural treasure: an intact courtyard home built by a wealthy Chinese family in the mid-nineteenth century, the Posayachinda residence.

The Posayachinda residence presents us with a rare glimpse of another way that Chinese glass paintings were used in nineteenth-century Bangkok: in the room that contains the ancestral altar, five glass paintings are affixed to the roof beams directly overhead, a central trio flanked by single pictures to the right and left (Fig. 17).⁴³ The paintings and their frames have an uncanny similarity to those at Wat Kanlayanamit, so much so that initial inspection suggests they might originally have been part of the same set, but close examination reveals that there are, in fact, slight differences.

The magnificent prang (Khmer-style redented spire) that graces so many postcards was completed by King Nangklao, who chose to have the outer surface of the 200-foot tower and its subsidiary spires adorned with a vast ceramic mosaic, many pieces Chinese in origin. The king likely also had a hand in importing the numerous large Chinese statues that ornament the grounds.

There is one notable distinction, however: the Wat Arun paintings are inscribed with text, which provides valuable insight into what the Chinese artist wanted to identify as important about the scene.

One of the most distinctive aesthetic innovations of King Nangklao's reign was the adaptation of zabao and bogu designs resembling those from imported glass paintings into the so-called Chinese altar table design in Thai temple murals, making the meander table the central visual element.

In addition to Wat Ratcha Orot and Wat Phakhinint, there are a handful of other monasteries, as well as one structure in the Grand Palace, that use Chinese altar tables as a primary mural design on the lower or upper walls.⁴⁴ More widespread and long-lasting was the use of this design as a secondary design on window and door panels or their reveals, in which capacity it can be observed at a number of very important temples, including Wat Pho, Wat Suthat, and Wat Bowonniwet.

That the design only achieved widespread use in these subordinate positions was a natural development, given the general preference in Thai mural painting to employ narrative scenes in the more prominent, eye-level wall spaces.

Glass Paintings of Birds and Flowers

Some manifestations of nature imagery in Thai murals suggest stylistic derivations from Chinese art, in particular the bird and flower pairings that have long been an established genre of Chinese painting.

Because bird-and-flower imagery tends to be much more generalized than the Chinese altar table design, it is more challenging to determine whether imported glass paintings played a role in the transfer of Chinese bird-and-flower imagery to Thai temple walls.

Nevertheless, that such models did exist as a visual resource available to artists is demonstrated by the set of glass paintings at Wat Suwannaram.

Renovated by King Nangklao in the first decade of his reign, the ordination hall of Wat Suwannaram is famous for the mural paintings by Luang Seni Borirak (Khong Pae) and Luang Wichit Chetsada (Thong Yu).

Over the windows and doors hang a set of Chinese glass paintings, the only element of the temple decor that is not characteristically Thai in conception and execution.

It is possible that the hanging doors had always been hung with a single image rather than a trio, in order to enhance the impact of the arrangement whereby a larger central object is flanked by two smaller ones, characteristic of the doors as well as the glass paintings on this wall.

It is difficult to say to what extent the glass paintings at Wat Suwannaram might have affected local mural painting practices.

Whereas the glass paintings featuring Chinese altar tables and scenes from Romance of the Three Kingdoms reflected new themes that began to appear in Thai temple murals during the first half of the nineteenth century, bird-and-flower imagery was already well entrenched in Thai art. Bird-and-flower scenes rarely, if ever, constitute the primary mural program on temple walls, but such imagery remains a popular choice for window and door panels or reveals and for enlivening the background of narrative scenes.

Accretion and Abundance

Despite the importance of glass paintings as channels of culture transfer as Siam sought new artistic ideas and motifs from China, it is important to bear in mind that paintings of this kind were atypical in the context of Thai Buddhist monasteries in Bangkok.

One possibility was raised in the discussion of Wat Nangnong, in which Three Kingdoms glass paintings were shown to complement the theme of royalty that was communicated by the Buddha image, murals, and decorative painting in the same temple.

More broadly speaking, Chinese glass paintings in the temples built or renovated by King Nangklao served as a reminder of his patronage, as he was principally associated with the China trade as well as the numerous Bangkok temples that he built or renovated with elements that were deemed Chinese in style.

McDaniel's articulation of the importance of abundance in the visual and material culture of Thai Buddhism can also help explain the presence and imagery of the glass paintings in these monastic settings.

When the junks came sailing back up the Chao Phraya River, laden with commodities, they would convert into floating shops right where they were anchored, and shoppers could paddle over on their private boats to browse numerous little luxuries.⁴⁶ Glass paintings were by no means the only imports from the China trade that were incorporated into Thai temple art and architecture: the large concrete statues of Chinese figures and animals that reportedly served as ballast for the trading ships still crowd the courtyards of many Bangkok monasteries; other imported goods that found their way into temple structures included great quantities of tiles, ceramics, and various other building materials.

What set the glass paintings apart was that not only were they a product of the extensive and profitable Sino-Siamese commerce, they also had the ability to reference it directly through their imagery, like the Wat Pho set featuring views of Canton, Macau, and ships traversing the Pearl River Delta.

But the principle of abundance is perhaps best communicated through the glass paintings with decorative themes, bird-and-flower compositions, and the auspicious arrangements that the Thais termed Chinese altar tables. The significance of the latter design was thoroughly altered by its translation into Thai mural paintings, losing any messages that might have been implicit in the original rebus-like arrangements of punning objects and instead multiplying them into an exuberant assortment of luxuries (see Figs.

But, as one might argue about Thai Buddhism more generally, in these mural designs materialism served a spiritual purpose: with the tables reconstrued as altars, everything upon them could be interpreted as an offering.⁴⁷ In this manner, the Chinese altar tables design, whether in the glass paintings or the murals that resemble them, was able to reflect the visual aesthetic of abundance and accretion within the temples themselves and on their real altars.

Thai Adaptations of Chinese Glass Paintings

Neither the creation of reverse paintings on glass nor the practice of hanging framed paintings over the windows, doors, or internal columns of temple buildings became widespread in central Siam following the Third Reign, but several examples are worthy of mention, and invite further research.

Flanking the base of the altar on the left and right sides, large standing screens almost in the form of cubicles contain multiple panels of Chinese painted glass with an assortment of images juxtaposed seemingly at random, among them bird-and-flower, assorted treasures, and narrative scenes probably from these screens were made in China and imported in their current form, or assembled locally from pre-existing glass paintings, but the impracticality of shipping such bulky yet exquisitely fragile structures and the arbitrariness of the juxtaposed imagery argues for the latter possibility.

They are pictures painted on the back of mirrors, confirms a book published by the Bureau of the Royal Household, but it does not specify where or when they were made.⁴⁸ One possibility is that the glass-painting techniques were borrowed for Buddhist content by local artisans; the other is that Thai templates were sent to China to request a custom-made set of images.

Chinese reverse glass paintings that incorporated mirrored glass were commonplace and frequently imported by Western countries (several examples can be seen at the Peabody Essex Museum), and some lingering patches of luster on the Posayachinda paintings suggest that they, and by extension their counterparts at Wat Kanlayanamit, might once have been mirrored (see Figs.

Both the ordination and assembly halls of Wat Suthat, another grand and important temple, contain trios of framed paintings over the windows and doors that resemble Thai-style paintings on glass of scenes and creatures from the Ramakian, the Thai version of the Ramayana (see Fig. 5).

However, close inspection suggests that they were painted not directly on glass but on very thin paper under glass either that, or some flaw in the process has caused the pigments to peel away from the glass in sheets, wrinkling in places and rotting at the edges, and even becoming dislodged in large sections (Fig. 20).⁴⁹ The sure hands behind the imagery and text raise the possibility that this set was more likely painted, and the inscriptions almost certainly written, by Thai artists, rather than a Chinese workshop copying Thai patterns.

Both King Nangklao and his successor, King Mongkut, contributed to renovations of these temples, so the Thai framed paintings were most likely made and installed either during or shortly after the period when the popularity of Chinese glass paintings had peaked.⁵⁰ There may have been a brief trend for making Thai-style framed pictures on the Chinese model just before the surge of Western cultural influences that dominated the latter half of the nineteenth century.

Wat Rakhang and Wat Prot Ket Chettharam contain sets of framed paintings that vary yet further in substance and style from Chinese precedents, demonstrating new knowledge of Euro-American artistic conventions.

The backgrounds demonstrate a rudimentary but competent knowledge of Western brushwork, and also employ perspective, occasionally over-exaggerated. Wat Prot Ket Chettharam displays an unusual set of framed paintings produced with tempera pigments on teak panels, although some of the images currently on view appear to be mechanical reproductions of originals that were stolen.⁵¹ The origins and artists of these paintings are unknown, yet it seems evident they were made locally by one or more painters who were both familiar with Thai design and intrigued by European architecture and pictorial conventions.⁵² It may be significant that they share some

qualities in common with the innovations introduced by Khrua In Khong, a painter who became renowned for his murals at Wat Bowonniwet and Wat Boromniwat during the reign of King Mongkut.

They were hung in the same manner as the Chinese paintings had been, typically in gilt frames, often in trios, over the windows and doors of temples, but the source of inspiration for medium and style gradually changed from Chinese glass paintings to European art. This parallels the broader shift of cultural paradigms in Siam.

If Thai Buddhism and its visual culture is characterized by accretion, this is because it is loathe to discard the material fabric already established in temple settings.